Happenings in Handmade

A CCI initiative

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TRUCK ART OF PAKISTAN



Eye-popping colours,
glittering metallic paint,
calligraphic Sufi verse,
poster-boy cricket heroes,
lofty landscapes, fighter
planes - just one sampling of
the rag bag of I'm-like-this-
only designs, fringed with
jingling bells, which identify
and announce each unique
cargo truck on the highways.

Who needs
logos or brand names?



Such is the popularity of this audacious art form that it is said to employ, for example, 50,000 people in Karachi city. On an average, a truck owner spends two years of his modest monthly income to paint his truck. An extroverted outpouring of all that defines his life and his passionate likes.



Besides, the more ornate the truck, the more impressed the client and the more willing he is to pay to hire it.

A renowned international scholar suggests that this travelling art originated over 2000 years ago when nomadic tribes decorated caravans of camels, their only companions across the drab and often rocky lands of the north and eastern region of Pakistan.





That sentiment carries over to this day, where the exuberant pastiches of the trucks provide a striking identity and a joyful wrap-around home for the trucker on his long, solo rides on the highway.

As a talent scout for the Smithsonian Folklife Festival 2002, Jonathan Mark Kenoyer, a career anthropology professor at the University of Michigan and a top US scholar of Pakistani indigenous art, arranged for a pair of truck artists to come and paint a vehicle on site. Their finished masterpiece, a 1976 Bedford, is now part of the Smithsonian's permanent collection.



More about this fascinating phenomenon in these articles. Long but gripping.